

An hour later, General Ambrose Burnside's Ninth Corps tried crossing at Ox Ford, only to be stopped by the strong Rebel defenses.

By evening it was apparent that the Army of Northern Virginia had been lurking in the midst of Union forces and was shielded behind a formidable set of fortifications shaped like an inverted "V." The apex was on Ox Ford and the rear was protected by steep-banked streams.

In a masterstroke, Lee had divided the Union army, but was himself too ill to organize an attack. Grant could not unite the two wings of his army, which were already on the south bank. He therefore retreated from this most ingenious of defensive arrangements, withdrawing across the river. A day passed. Then, on the evening of May 26, Grant feinted to the west, and again pivoted his army to the southeast.